



Using a calculator

CALCULATORS ARE MACHINES THAT WORK OUT THE ANSWERS TO SOME MATHEMATICAL PROBLEMS.

Calculators are designed to make math easier, but there are a few things to be aware of when using them.

Introducing the calculator

A modern calculator is a handheld electronic device that is used to find the answers to mathematical problems. Most calculators are operated in a similar way (as described here), but it may be necessary to read the instructions for a particular model.

Using a calculator

Be careful that functions are entered in the correct order, or the answers the calculator gives will be wrong.

For example, to find the answer to the calculation:

$$(7 + 2) \times 9 =$$

Enter these keys, making sure to include all parts of the calculation, including the parentheses.

$$(7 + 2) \times 9 = 81$$

Not

$$7 + 2 \times 9 = 25$$

calculator does product $2 \times 9 = 18$, then sum $18 + 7 = 25$

Estimating answers

Calculators can only give answers according to the keys that have been pressed. It is useful to have an idea of what answer to expect since a small mistake can give a very wrong answer.

For example

$$2006 \times 198$$

must be close to

$$2000 \times 200$$

this would give the answer 400,000

So if the calculator gives the answer **40,788** it is clear that the numbers have not been entered correctly—one "0" is missing from what was intended:

$$206 \times 198$$

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Collecting and organizing data **204–205**

FREQUENTLY USED KEYS



ON

This button turns the calculator on—most calculators turn themselves off automatically if they are left unused for a certain period of time.



Number pad

This contains the basic numbers that are needed for math. These buttons can be used individually or in groups to create larger numbers.



Standard arithmetic keys

These cover all the basic mathematical functions: multiplication, division, addition, and subtraction, as well as the essential equals sign.



Decimal point

This key works in the same way as a written decimal point—it separates whole numbers from decimals. It is entered in the same way as any of the number keys.



Cancel

The cancel key clears all recent entries from the memory. This is useful when starting a new calculation because it makes sure no unwanted values are retained.



Delete

This clears the last value that was entered into the calculator, rather than wiping everything from the memory. It is sometimes labeled "CE" (clear entry).



Recall button

This recalls a value from the calculator's memory—it is useful for calculations with many parts that use numbers or stages from earlier in the problem.